# 10
# Language and Gender

Consider the following two questions:

- If you could systematically record every word spoken on a given day by 200 female college students and 200 male college students, as Matthias Mehl and his colleagues did, which speakers do you think would be more talkative on average?
- Which of the following conversations[1] was spoken by an all-female group and which by an all-male group of US high school students? These students were debating the importance for survivors of a plane crash in a desert of items such as sunglasses, a compass, a gun, a first aid kit, and so on.

**Group A**

*S*: wouldn't you need the sunglasses?
*C*: yeah, that's what I think
*S*: because it would be really hot and protect yourself from the sun and you'd be able to see more
*G*: yeah, but if you're trying to live, does it matter [whether you can see?
*C*: [you can go *blind*
*G*: exactly, but if you're trying to survive, does it really matter?
*C*: (*sounding irritated*) I wouldn't [want to go *blind*

*Living Language: An Introduction to Linguistic Anthropology*, Third Edition. Laura M. Ahearn.
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*S*: [it does, because if you were blind you wouldn't be able to see what you were doing and you would end up dying anyway. You'd have less chance of surviving anyway.

*G*: yeah, but you're not likely to go blind unless you're looking right up into the sun.

**Group B**

*C*: (*pointing*) right, what did you put?

*M*: compass.

*C*: (*pointing*) what did you put?

*T*: I put sunglasses

*C*: right, I put the parachute (*gives long explanation for choosing it*)

*Other voices:* mirror, mirror… . the torch

C: and you could use a gun, couldn't you? You could shoot –

*H*: you could shoot the pilot

*C*: right. So has anyone changed their mind? (*pointing*) What do you think?

*H*: I say compass

*T*: I think sunglasses are quite important because you have to be able to see what it says on the compass for a start (laughter from the group)

*H*: you could just go like that (mimes shading eyes) shut your eyes for a moment

*C*: right. You go (*pointing*) Say why you thought the first aid kit.

In answering these questions, you probably drew on your first-hand experiences of how males and females use language, as well as (consciously or unconsciously) various language ideologies concerning the gendered nature of communication, especially whether men or women are more talkative, cooperative, or competitive in daily conversations. We will return to each of these cases in the pages that follow.

In addition to examining the research that enables us to answer the two questions that open this chapter, we will also explore many other researchers' findings and look more broadly at the relationship of language to gender, addressing in particular the following questions:

- What is gender, and how does it relate to language?
- Do men and women speak alike or differently?

- Do women and men of all ages and all ethnic, racial, and cultural backgrounds share the same gendered differences in their language use?
- How can we separate myths (that is, powerful but factually incorrect language ideologies) from reality in the area of language and gender, and why are these myths so influential?

In the process of addressing these questions, we will review the two studies cited above regarding the relative talkativeness of male and female college students and the cooperative or competitive nature of groups of male and female high school students engaged in a problem-solving exercise. These studies and others shed light on the fascinating complexities of language and gender. First, however, let us discuss what gender is and how it relates to language.

## What is Gender, and How Does it Relate to Language?

Upon hearing that a baby has been born, many people in the US and elsewhere immediately ask, "Is it a boy or a girl?" Right from birth, therefore (if not sooner, since prenatal tests often reveal the sex of the baby long before birth), the gendered categorization of the person begins. This categorization is usually dichotomous – that is, the child is said to be *either* a girl *or* a boy – and the process of categorization seems so obvious, so "natural," that many people take it totally for granted and immediately begin acting upon assumptions about how girls and boys are said to behave (Livia and Hall 1997; McElhinny 2003a). It is worth reflecting, however, on some of the many complexities and assumptions that underlie this seemingly simple act of sex assignment.

One way that some scholars have sought to clarify sex and gender is to say that the term "sex" refers to a person's biological existence as either a female or male human being, and the term "gender" refers to a person's cultural or social identity as either a woman or a man (or a girl or a boy) in a particular society at a particular historical moment. In this view, one's sex is immutable and given at birth, whereas one's gender identity can change, depending on what cultural practices of masculinity or femininity a person might choose to perform at different times.

Many scholars have challenged this sex = biology and gender = culture distinction, however. As Penelope Eckert and Sally McConnell-Ginet write, "there is no obvious point at which sex leaves off and gender begins, partly because there is no single objective biological criterion for male or female sex" (2003:10). Sex is based on a complex combination of anatomy (in the form of internal and external genitalia and reproductive organs), hormones (testosterone and estrogen are only two of the many important hormones that affect sexual characteristics), and chromosomes (usually, but not always, XX or XY). Anomalies in any of these areas can result in what is known as an "intersexed" individual – a phenomenon that is more common than many people realize because it is often taboo to discuss babies who are not easily categorized as either male or female at birth. Estimates of the frequency of intersexed individuals vary tremendously, but there seem to be between 1 in 30,000 to about 1 in 1,000 babies who are born with sexually ambiguous genitalia, many of whom are considered candidates for surgical interventions of one kind or another (Preves 2003:2; Bing and Bergvall 1996:8). In addition to these babies, many more individuals (estimates range between 1 and 4 percent of all births) are born with hormonal or chromosomal anomalies that only become evident later in childhood or during puberty (Blackless et al. 2000:151; Preves 2003:2; Eckert and McConnell-Ginet 2003:11). The fact that these individuals are usually deemed so abnormal as to require medical interventions points to the cultural power of the dichotomous gender ideology that is dominant in so many countries – a power that is now being resisted by a growing movement of intersexed and transgender individuals who are fighting to have the right to be accepted as they are (cf. Chase 2008). Thus, many scholars consider both sex and gender to be concepts that are influenced by cultural and social norms and practices.

For the purposes of this chapter, we will consider gender to be built upon a set of culturally and historically specific practices that amplify, simplify, and give meaning to perceived or actual biological differences. Penelope Eckert and Sally McConnell-Ginet (2003:31–32) identify the following four characteristics as central to the concept of gender:

- *Gender is learned.* As is the case with other sociocultural practices, children either unconsciously adopt or are consciously instructed

in gender-appropriate behavior that varies across societies and throughout historical time.

- *Gender is collaborative.* Though it is individuals who engage in gendered activities, these activities are learned in, and acquire meaning from, social contexts. Gender, like other aspects of identity such as race or ethnicity, is a joint accomplishment that is constructed in and through interactions with others.
- *Gender is not something we have, but something we do.* Judith Butler's concept of the performativity of gender, discussed in Chapter 9, asserts that people continuously reinforce or reconfigure their gender identities. Gender, according to Butler, is not a static and unchanging element of someone's identity but rather an ongoing process of *doing* that involves choices in how that person dresses, acts, and speaks. "The fact is," Eckert and McConnell-Ginet write, "that gender requires work, and when aspects of gender are not consistently performed at all levels of society they can wither away" (2003:32).
- *Gender involves asymmetry.* Eckert and McConnell-Ginet are joined by many other social scientists in their insistence that inequality is built into gender at a very fundamental level. Men and women, and masculine and feminine ways of acting or speaking, are rarely considered simply different; there are usually value judgments that accompany such assessments of gendered difference. Men, and those things that are deemed masculine, are not always more prestigious; there is complexity and variability depending on the particular social context. Moreover, there are multiple masculinities and femininities even within one society, so judgments about prestige or appropriateness will also vary. What is often the case, however, is that those qualities associated with men and masculinity tend to be taken for granted – tend to be the default ways of behaving or speaking, in other words. Scholars, drawing on the important linguistic concept of markedness, call these masculine practices "unmarked." They are taken as the norm for all humans, and anything that departs from them, such as perceived feminine ways of speaking or acting, are considered different or "marked."

Markedness also helps to illuminate gender as it appears in the realm of grammar. The use of masculine generic pronouns, for example, is

supposed to enable the speaker to refer to anyone – male or female. Consider the following sentence: "If a student wants to do well, _____ should study hard for the test." According to many prescriptive grammarians, the appropriate pronoun for the blank in the following sentence is "he" because the masculine pronoun in English is unmarked and therefore supposed to encompass a more generic meaning than the feminine pronoun. In recent years, however, this prescription has been challenged by editors and even some English teachers. Using *he*, *his*, and *him* as common-sex pronouns is now widely considered sexist, if not misleading, according to the classic reference book, *The Chicago Manual of Style*, a sentence such as, "If a student wants to do well, _____ should study hard for the test," could therefore either be converted into the plural ("If students want to do well, they should study hard for the test"), or singular "they" could be used ("If a student wants to do well, they should study hard for the test"). This singular "they" has been in use to refer to a person of unknown gender since at least 1300, according to Merriam Webster's dictionary (2019); what is fairly new is the use of singular "they" to refer to a person of known nonbinary gender. In fact, this use of singular "they" was even declared the American Dialect Society's 2015 Word of the Year, and stating one's pronouns has become accepted practice in many professional, academic, and social contexts in the United States.[2]

In a fascinating ethnographic and linguistic study of the use by women of masculine generics in Hebrew and Arabic, Amalia Sa'ar reveals that female speakers of both these languages in Israel often use masculine grammatical forms as generics to refer to themselves and their female addressees (Sa'ar 2007:408). For example, one 34-year-old Hebrew-speaking fashion designer made this remark to Sa'ar to explain why she had become self-employed: "'One day you♂ suddenly realize♂ that you♂ are♂ a mother and all you♂ wish♂ to do is stay home with the children'" (2007:413).[3] Similarly, an 80-year-old Arabic-speaking woman answered her neighbor's question, "How have you been?" with the following: "'Very poorly♂ lately; I don't know♂ what it is – my health is not good'" (2007:415). Sa'ar found that the women who used these masculine grammatical forms generally did so unconsciously. When she brought this practice to their attention, they had several different kinds of reactions. Some women felt it helped them participate in public or professional spheres to

use masculine grammatical forms. Others thought it was a function of their particular dialect of Hebrew or Arabic. If gender is, as Judith Butler claims, something that we do rather than something that we have, Sa'ar asks, then what gender are these women "doing"? Masculinity? Femininity? A combination? A redefinition of one or both of these genders? Sa'ar concludes that whatever sort of gender is being performed when women use masculine generics, it would serve their interests far better if they were to begin using feminine grammatical forms, both to refer to themselves and to address mixed- and same-sex groups generically because, Sa'ar claims, "Generalized feminine talk brings the female gender to the forefront, instead of denying it" (2007:426).

Teens in Argentina have been taking a different approach to grammatical gender. As Samantha Schmidt reported in the Washington Post, "In classrooms and daily conversations, young people are changing the way they speak and write – replacing the masculine 'o' or the feminine 'a' with the gender-neutral 'e' in certain words – in order to change what they see as a deeply gendered culture" (Schmidt 2019). So, for example, as one teenage activist, Natalia Mira, awaited student government election results, she exclaimed, "Estamos literalmente empatades," instead of "empatados" ("We are literally tied"). Departments from at least five universities across Argentina have agreed to accept work written in the inclusive gender-neutral style. The change is by no means accepted by everyone, however, and there are strong language ideologies on both sides of the issue.

Grammatical gender involves much more than the use of generic pronouns and word endings, however. The 7,000 or so languages in the world encode gender grammatically in many different ways (including not at all). The grammatical categories of some languages require speakers to assign a gender when using a personal pronoun, such as "she" or "he" in English, whereas the grammatical categories of other languages, such as the dialect of Nepali spoken in the village of Junigau, where I have conducted fieldwork, does not assign gender at all in any personal pronoun – but does assign several different levels of social status in second- and third-person pronouns. Sometimes, grammatical gender involves not just personal pronouns but all nouns, as in Spanish or French. In other languages, there are pronouns and/or noun classes that extend beyond "masculine" or "feminine," such as German, in which a "neuter" category of nouns and pronouns exists.

This "neuter" category does not always correlate with social gender, however, as can be seen by the fact that the German word for girl, *Mädchen*, takes the neuter article "das" rather than the feminine article, "die." Another example of noun classifications that extend beyond "masculine" and "feminine" is the one mentioned in Chapter 1 of the four classes of nouns in Dyirbal, an endangered indigenous language of Australia (Lakoff 1987:93; Dixon 1982):

1 *Bayi*: (human) males; animals
2 *Balan*: (human) females; water; fire; fighting
3 *Balam*: nonflesh food
4 *Bala*: everything not in the other classes.

There is no simple one-to-one mapping, therefore, of grammatical and social gender onto each other. Researchers have shown, however, that what might appear to be an arbitrary gender categorization of items or individuals in a particular language often seems anything but arbitrary to speakers of that language (McElhinny 2003b:848). As we saw in Chapter 5, grammatical categories can powerfully influence how people make connections and groupings in real-world actions. It may very well be the case, therefore, that for languages that group terms in gender categories that link women with water, fire, and fighting, as in Dyirbal, for example, speakers might be predisposed (but *not* required in a deterministic way, remember) to view these items as linked in some way. Still, the relationship between social and grammatical gender is so complex that it is far more useful to take a broader approach to the study of language and gender rather than to focus exclusively on how particular languages encode gender grammatically.[4]

Indeed, Elinor Ochs (1992) made an important contribution to the study of language and gender when she noted that a large part of the way that language and gender are connected involves indirect rather than direct indexicality. As one of the book's four key terms, indexicality is especially useful in studying the relationship between language and gender because it helps us understand which linguistic features, styles, or discourses index, or "point to," gendered identities or practices. In her classic 1992 article, "Indexing Gender," Ochs states that though few features of any language directly and exclusively index gender, many features, communicative styles, and stances more

indirectly and complexly index gender by alluding to, and helping to constitute, other domains of social reality, which then relate to gender (1992:343). This sort of indirect indexicality works differently in each particular community of practice.

For example, Ochs describes two very different styles of linguistic interaction between mothers and their children – in white, middle-class communities in the United States, and in Western Samoa. As readers will remember from Chapter 4, the white, middle-class American mothers that Ochs studied tended to accommodate to their children, using simplified language and treating them as more competent conversational partners than they were capable of being. Western Samoan mothers, in contrast, refused to accommodate to their children in these ways, preferring instead to reserve such linguistic accommodation for high-status foreigners who had trouble speaking Samoan. Both sets of mothers used accommodation in the form of simplified language to nonfluent speakers – but they did so with two very different groups of conversation partners. Ochs argues that because accommodation is universally associated with the actions of lower-ranking individuals in the presence of higher-status individuals, the uses in two different communities of practice to two different groups of individuals (children vs. foreigners) lead to the constitution of two different social identities. In the United States, Ochs maintains, children are socialized into viewing mothers as accommodating, addressee-oriented, and relatively low in status, whereas in Samoa, it is the children who are socialized to become accommodating themselves (Ochs 1992:344–345). Thus, the same linguistic practice – accommodation to a nonfluent speaker – indirectly indexes two very different social identities in these two societies (cf. Bucholtz and Hall 2004:476).

## Do Men and Women Speak Alike or Differently?

Language ideologies concerning the alleged differences in how women and men speak have created a multi-million-dollar self-help industry consisting of books, workshops, and career seminars that purport to explain these differences and advise readers or clients as to what, if anything, to do about them. Books such as Deborah Tannen's *You Just Don't Understand: Women and Men in Conversation*, for example,

assume categorical, dichotomous, essential differences in the ways that men and women speak (See Figure 10.1). Women, according to Tannen, are much more likely to engage in "rapport talk" – that is, talk that cooperatively establishes and maintains social relationships. Men, on the other hand, according to Tannen, tend to use "report talk" – talk that conveys straightforward information rather than emotion or gossip (Tannen 1990:74ff).

While Tannen is a well-respected sociolinguist who has conducted her own research in several different areas, in *You Just Don't Understand* she relied primarily on anecdotal evidence from her own experiences as well as some early work done in the area of language and gender research in the 1970s and 1980s. In much of this early work, gendered differences in communicative styles were simply assumed rather than investigated systematically. Men, these researchers (e.g., Maltz and Borker 1982) asserted, were more likely to compete for the floor and to interrupt when others were speaking, while women spoke more cooperatively, asking more questions, linking their comments to others' comments, and rarely interrupting. Scholars in these early years of language and gender research largely accepted that these sorts of fundamental differences existed, and then they proceeded to advocate various approaches for dealing with such allegedly different gendered communicative styles. Some suggested that women should take assertiveness training to learn how to speak like men. Others advised women and men that such differences were akin to cross-cultural differences and could therefore best be dealt with through attempts at greater understanding and tolerance. And still others felt that differences in communicative style reflected deep gender inequalities in society and prescribed actions to remedy these injustices. But what all these early scholars in the field of language and gender assumed was the existence of dramatic across-the-board differences in how women and men talked.

In recent years, however, this basic assumption of the existence of substantial gender differences in communicative style has been challenged. Psychologist Janet Hyde, a researcher who specializes in meta-analyses – that is, analyses of multiple studies on a given topic – has put forward a Gender Similarities Hypothesis. According to Hyde (2005, 2014), the gender differences model that dominates the popular media is inaccurate at best and harmful at worst when it comes to most variables, including alleged gender differences in communication. Among




*"And do you, Deborah Tannen, think they know what they're talking about?"*

**Figure 10.1** Cartoon referring to author Deborah Tannen's ability to understand gendered language. Tannen writes about the communication between men and women.
*Source*: From *The New Yorker*, March 20, 1995. Peter Steiner/The New Yorker Collection/The Cartoon Bank.

the variables on which Hyde conducted meta-analyses were those involving verbal and nonverbal behaviors among males and females of various ages. As Table 10.1 indicates, almost all of these behaviors showed gender differences that were close to zero or very small. In the studies that Hyde analyzed, only two communicative behaviors, spelling and smiling, showed moderate differences (both in this case

favoring females), and none showed large differences. "Stated another way," Hyde writes, "within-gender variability is typically much larger than between-gender variability" (2007:260).

As Hyde herself readily admits, the nuances of particular contexts are by necessity glossed over in these large meta-analyses, and it is exactly these sorts of nuances that are of greatest interest to linguistic anthropologists. And yet, there is a benefit to considering these large-scale quantitative analyses in conjunction with smaller, more ethnographically rich studies.

Consider the issue of the relationship between gender and talkativeness, for instance. Hyde's meta-analysis relies upon an earlier meta-analysis done by two other psychologists on 73 different studies that quantified in some way the amount of talk produced by males and females (Leaper and Smith 2004). All 73 of these studies were conducted among children 17 years of age or

**Table 10.1** Findings of Hyde's meta-analyses regarding gender differences in communicative behavior.

| Area of research | Number of studies analyzed | Size of gender difference (with females [F] or males [M] favored) |
|---|---|---|
| Reading comprehension | 23 | Close to zero (F) |
| Verbal reasoning | 5 | Close to zero (F) |
| Vocabulary | 44 | Close to zero (F) |
| Affiliative speech | 46 | Small (F) |
| Assertive speech | 75 | Small (M) |
| Conversational interruption | 70 | Small (M) |
| Self-disclosure | 205 | Small (F) |
| Speech production | 12 | Small (F) |
| Talkativeness | 73 | Small (F) |
| Smiling | 418 | Moderate (F) |
| Spelling | 5 | Moderate (F) |

*Source*: Adapted from Hyde (2005:583–586) and Cameron (2007b:43).

younger (mostly preschoolers and children in the middle years of childhood), and they varied in terms of where the study took place (home, school, laboratory) as well as who the conversation partners were for the children (other children or adults). On average, across all these different contexts, girls produced slightly more talk than boys, though the researchers termed this difference "negligible" (Leaper and Smith 2004:993). A later meta-analysis on talkativeness among adults in 63 different studies also found a "negligible" difference, though in the opposite direction. "Contrary to prediction, men tended to talk significantly more than women," the authors concluded (Leaper and Ayres 2007:353; cf. Holmes 1998; James and Drakich 1993).

Another study was undertaken by Matthias Mehl and his colleagues in order to study talkativeness not just in particular contexts or conversations, as previous studies such as those analyzed by Leaper and his colleagues had documented, but among large groups of people for extended periods of time (Mehl et al. 2007). As Mehl and his colleagues reported in the prestigious journal *Science*, they were concerned about wildly inaccurate assertions regarding the relative talkativeness of women and men that were circulating in the media. One source for these erroneous figures was a popular book on "the female brain" that alleged that women spoke an average of 20,000 words per day while men spoke only an average of 7,000 words (Brizendine 2006). These figures, Mehl reported, had struck linguist Mark Liberman as implausible, and in columns in *The Boston Globe* as well as in the wonderful blog, *Language Log*, Liberman (2006) fact-checked them and found them to be based on absolutely no research at all but rather on unscientific estimates.[5]

Mehl and his colleagues conducted a study of almost 400 college students – the study mentioned at the outset of this chapter – in order to measure gender differences in the average number of words spoken over the course of the research subjects' waking hours (Mehl et al. 2007). The college students (divided roughly equally between women and men) were rigged up with digital recorders that were programmed to record for 30 seconds every 12.5 minutes. The students could not tell when they were being recorded. The researchers then transcribed all the words spoken by the participants and extrapolated from these figures to estimate the total number of words spoken over the course of an average day for these individuals. The findings

showed that female college students spoke an average of 16,215 words per day, while men spoke an average of 15,669 words per day – but this difference was not statistically significant. "Thus," write Mehl and his co-authors, "the data fail to reveal a reliable sex difference in daily word use. Women and men both use on average about 16,000 words per day, with very large individual differences around this mean … We therefore conclude, on the basis of available empirical evidence, that the widespread and highly publicized stereotype about female talkativeness is unfounded" (Mehl et al. 2007:82).

Before considering what might account for the discrepancy between common language ideologies regarding gender differences in talkativeness and actual empirical research, let us examine another area in which there are widespread assumptions about gendered communicative styles – the competitive vs. cooperative (or "affiliative" vs. "assertive") nature of men's and women's speech. The large-scale meta-analyses by Hyde (2005) and Leaper and Ayres (2007) found differences in this area that accorded with popular language ideologies that depict women as using talk more cooperatively and men as using talk more competitively – but these differences, which showed up on average across dozens of separate studies, were "small" or "negligible."

A look at more in-depth research in which talk is analyzed in actual social contexts illuminates some of the complexities that get erased in larger quantitative studies and in many of the earlier research that assumed the existence of essential gender differences. For example, Marjorie Harness Goodwin has conducted extremely detailed, long-term analyses of the linguistic and social interactions in several groups of children – most notably, a mixed-age, mixed-sex group of African American children in Philadelphia, and a racially and ethnically mixed group of girls from their fourth through sixth grade in Los Angeles (Goodwin 1990, 2006). Goodwin audio- or videotaped hundreds of hours of naturally occurring interactions while these children played among themselves and with other boys and girls. In her two books about these children's social worlds, she interweaves close analysis of "talk-in-interaction" with insights gathered from ethnographic fieldwork – a very different methodology from that which is generally employed by child psychologists or sociolinguists (Goodwin 2006:15). Rather than conducting interviews or psychological tests, Goodwin immerses herself in the actual social worlds of the children as much as possible and presents them as agents

who construct their own social relationships and hierarchies through talk (1990:283).

Goodwin's long-term ethnographic and linguistic fieldwork enables her to understand some of the complexities of children's social worlds and leads her to oppose simplistic, dualistic representations of girls as cooperative and boys as competitive. In her first study of the children of Maple Street in Philadelphia, *He-Said-She-Said: Talk As Social Organization Among Black Children*, Goodwin (1990) conducts close conversation analysis and concludes that in some of the girls' activities, such as making rings out of glass bottle rims, the girls cooperate and use supportive talk. In other pastimes, however, such as pretend play, "he-said-she-said" arguments, or fabricated conflicts known as "instigating," the girls are anything but cooperative. In these interactions, their talk displays competition and asymmetry, often using the same sorts of directives and other linguistic forms that boys use during their play. And when the girls and boys on Maple Street played together, there was a mixture of linguistic forms and social interactions. Thus, Goodwin argues, the notion of "separate worlds" or "separate cultures" for boys and girls was not at all borne out by her research. Moreover, the stereotype of girls as always affiliative, nonconfrontational, and egalitarian within their same-sex play groups was also contradicted by the actions of the girls she studied. "Not only do girls establish hierarchical arrangements among members of their groups, but they also differentiate themselves and establish implicit rankings by forming coalitions against particular girls" (Goodwin 1990:133). The variety in forms of talk and forms of social organization among these girls and boys speaks to the need, Goodwin asserts, for studies of language and gender to be "grounded in detailed analysis of specific contexts of use" (1990:137). The contribution that a focus on specific activities and communities of practice makes to linguistic research on gender, Bonnie McElhinny notes, is that it shifts the research question away from what the differences are in men and women's (or boys' and girls') speech – a question that makes unwarranted assumptions about the existence of differences and also serves to perpetuate and exaggerate the dichotomous nature of gender categories – to research questions involving "when, whether, and how men and women's speech are done in similar and different ways" (McElhinny 2003a:29).

In her second ethnography, *The Hidden Life of Girls: Games of Stance, Status, and Exclusion*, Goodwin (2006) describes the linguistic and social interactions of several different groups of children. In her analysis of the actions and words of one particular group of ethnically and racially mixed fourth- to sixth-grade girls in a private school in Los Angeles, she documents how they confronted the boys and several school officials, demanding to have the right to play on the soccer field that the boys had been monopolizing at recess. The girls also complained to the vice principal about a male aide who had been siding with the boys. Eventually, the girls managed to change the school's policy so that access to the soccer and football fields was shared between the boys and girls, and a sign-up process was implemented. For the next year or so, the girls' participation in team sports increased dramatically, but then, according to Goodwin, their interest waned because the boys often refused to pass the ball to them, and some boys even sexually harassed the girls through actions such as pinching their nipples while they were playing soccer. Goodwin concludes,

> Despite problems, the girls did succeed in initiating a new moral order on their own terms. The overtly political activity of the girls countering the boys challenges the view of girls as non-competitive and displays quite dramatically their engagement in issues of justice and fairness; it also provides a view of girls as wielders of authority and instruments of change. (2006:106)

Other examples of research that illuminates complex linguistic and social interactions among girls and contradicts the stereotype of girls as cooperative and egalitarian can be found in the work of Penelope Eckert. In an article entitled, "Cooperative Competition in Adolescent 'Girl Talk,'" Eckert (1993) shows how six high school girls use a conversation to co-construct the social norms against which the girls judge and compete against one another. Drawing on Bourdieu's concept of symbolic capital, which refers to the status acquired by those who are able to speak in highly valued ways in appropriate contexts, Eckert argues that because of the gender dynamics in the high school she studied in the 1980s, the girls acquired symbolic capital largely through their relationships with particular kinds of boys. In the conversation Eckert analyzes in her "Cooperative Competition" article, a group of girls, most of whom have not seen one another since junior high school, compete only indirectly because they

perceive a conflict between the goal of being "successful" and the goal of being "likable" (1993:37). Moreover, the meanings of these two words are also up for interpretation during the conversation. The girls discuss the different paths they have taken in high school, their differing attitudes toward using go-betweens instead of asking boys out themselves, the pros and cons of dating "popular" boys, and the advisability of marrying within or outside of one's religion. On all these topics, the girls perform intricate linguistic and social negotiations that allow them to compete against one another without appearing to do so. Eckert concludes, "Therefore, their noncompetitive performance in this interaction, which allows each girl to display her understanding of human nature and her ability to resolve conflict and create community, can be seen as part of the competition" (1993:37).

Despite the competitiveness in this conversation, which contradicts language ideologies in which females are portrayed as more cooperative by nature, the girls Eckert studied do engage in a social and linguistic practice stereotypically associated with girls and women: gossip, or "girl talk." Indeed, Eckert argues that because females in the United States during the 1980s often accrued social status by virtue of the males they dated or married, girls and women had good reasons to use gossip to assess one another's prestige. Thus, in the community of practice Eckert studied (a high school in Michigan during the 1980s), gossip was a gendered form of communication that both reflected and reinforced inequalities between males and females.

Gossip, however, like almost all other linguistic forms and genres, is not the sole province of one gender. As Deborah Cameron compellingly demonstrates in her article, "Performing Gender Identity: Young Men's Talk and the Construction of Heterosexual Masculinity" (Cameron 1997), even a fairly mundane conversation among several male college students can involve gossip. Cameron defines gossip as the discussion of people who are known to the participants but who are not currently present in which the focus is on critically examining these individuals' appearance, dress, social behavior, and sexual mores. Gossip usually affirms the solidarity of an in-group by constructing absent others as an out-group, whose behavior is minutely examined and found wanting (1997:51, 54; cf. Besnier 2009). Using this definition of gossip, the men in the conversation Cameron studied were certainly gossiping.

There is an interesting twist to Cameron's analysis, for it is actually a re-analysis of a conversation tape-recorded and analyzed by a male student of hers for a class assignment. In the student's original analysis of the conversation, in which he himself was a participant, along with several of his male friends, the student argued that the conversation was an example of typically masculine talk because the topics discussed included sports, women, and alcohol. Cameron agreed that these topics were present, but she also saw something else as well – aspects of the conversation that did not conform to the prevailing language ideologies about differences in how men and women talk. The student's analysis – like the analyses of all scholars, whether well-seasoned researchers or amateurs – was "*partial*: it was shaped by expectations that caused some things to leap out of the record as 'significant,' while other things went unremarked," Cameron declared (1997:47; emphasis in the original). While the male student considered the content of the conversation to involve mainly gender-typical subjects such as "wine, women, and sports" (the title the student chose for his paper), Cameron, on the other hand, argued that the conversation dwelled more on typically "feminine" topics, such as clothing and bodily appearance. And in the area of linguistic form, the conversation "must be judged as highly cooperative," Cameron argues (1997:55), because of the latching (when participants link their utterances immediately onto the previous participant's utterance), repetitions, and multiple tokens of hearer support. Take, for example, this segment of the conversation (Cameron 1997:53–54):[6]

| | |
|---|---|
| BRYAN: | uh you know that really gay guy in our Age of Revolution class who sits in front of us? he wore shorts again, by the way, it's like 42 degrees out he wore shorts again [laughter] [Ed:That guy] it's like a speedo, he wears a speedo to class (.) he's got incredibly skinny legs [Ed: it's worse] you know = |
| ED: | =you know like those shorts women volleyball players wear? it's like those (.) it's l[ike |
| BRYAN: | [you know what's even more ridicu[lous? when |
| ED: | [French cut spandex] |
| BRYAN: | you wear those shorts and like a parka on … |
| | (*5 lines omitted*) |

| | |
|---|---|
| BRYAN: | he's either got some condition that he's got to like have his legs exposed at all times or else he's got really good legs = |
| ED: | =he's probably he'[s like |
| CARL: | [he really likes |
| BRYAN: | =he |
| ED: | =he's like at home combing his leg hairs = |
| CARL: | his legs = |
| BRYAN: | he doesn't have any leg hair though = [*yes* and oh |
| ED: | =he *real* [*ly* likes |
| ED: | his legs = |
| AL: | =very long very white and very skinny |
| BRYAN: | those ridiculous Reeboks that are always (indeciph) and goofy white socks always striped = [tube socks |
| ED: | =that's [right |
| ED: | he's the antithesis of man |

Despite the ways in which the form and content of this conversation contradict language ideologies regarding gendered styles of talk, Cameron does not claim that these men are subverting or challenging gender norms in any way. Indeed, they seem mainly to be concerned with performing a gender identity that is highly normative in its heterosexual masculinity. In this sense, Cameron agrees with her student's analysis. And yet, the participants in the conversation achieve this goal of reasserting their normative gender identities through linguistic practices that have been associated with femininity rather than masculinity – gossip about others' clothing and behavior, and linguistic forms that are cooperative rather than competitive in nature. It is therefore unhelpful, Cameron concludes, "for linguists to continue to use models of gendered speech which imply that masculinity and femininity are monolithic constructs, automatically giving rise to predictable (and utterly different) patterns of verbal interaction" (1997:62).

An excellent example of the complexities and variations inherent in gendered language use can be found in Kira Hall's (1995) analysis of the ways in which phone sex operators in San Francisco used stereotypically ultra-feminine styles in order to cater to their clients' expectations and language ideologies. Just as Cameron's study of the speech

of college men reminds us that no linguistic forms or conversational topics are unique to one sex, so too, does Hall's study remind us that even when individuals are using language in ways that accord with gendered language ideologies, the meanings behind their words, and the power dynamics associated with their interactions, can be quite complex and varied. Hall explains that the phone sex operators she studied (who included 11 women of different ethnicities and sexual orientations, and one bisexual Mexican American man who portrayed himself as a female heterosexual to his callers) used linguistic features often labeled as "feminine" and "powerless," such as raising the pitch of their voices and using multiple adjectives to describe their clothes and bodies, thereby depicting themselves in their phone conversations with their paying male customers as submissive and engaging in stereotypically feminine activities. Their linguistic styles closely resembled that of this prerecorded phone sex message, in which a woman describes her new job as a phone sex operator:[7]

> oo::f:: – i'm so ((in breathy voice)) excited. – i just got a hot new job. (0.8) well, – ((in slight Southern accent)) i've been bored lately. .hh – i live in a small town and my husband travels a lot, (0.5) i have lots of time on my hands. – .hhh of course, i've always managed to stay busy. (0.4) lots of girlfriends, you know, – ((whispered)) i love to shop, – i ((laugh)) ^pract^ically live at the mall it seems. (Hall 1995:192)

As submissive and reinforcing of certain stereotypes as these sorts of messages are, Hall maintains that the phone sex operators viewed their use of these linguistic features as powerful and considered themselves to be in a superior position within the conversations. "The operators who participated in the study reported that they are completely in control of each conversation: they initiate and dominate the conversational exchange; they are creators of the fantasy story line and scenario; they can decide what kind of fantasies they will entertain, and they can terminate the conversation with a simple flick of the index finger" (Hall 1995:204). And yet, these workers in the phone sex industry also admitted that using this language and catering to the fantasies of their male callers could feel degrading and restricting, and several seemed worried that they might reinforce negative and inaccurate stereotypes of women through their conversations. Nevertheless, these phone sex operators also felt that it would be "ridiculous" to attribute any power to their male callers. Hall concludes, therefore,

that language, gender, and power should be analyzed within particular communities of practice; doing so will allow for greater nuance in understanding and representing these complexities.

Hall's conclusion in the specific case of phone sex operators in San Francisco applies equally well to the question posed at the outset of this section: do men and women speak alike or differently? There is no single answer to this question that would be applicable across all contexts. Men and women (or boys and girls) sometimes speak in similar ways, and sometimes speak differently from each other – it all depends on who is speaking to whom, when, where, and to what audiences. Many received notions, or language ideologies, concerning the alleged differences in how women and men speak have been disproved by the research of scholars such as Deborah Cameron, Marjorie Harness Goodwin, Janet Hyde, and Matthias Mehl. We will return at the end of this chapter to consider why such assumptions of gender difference in communicative styles continue to be so prevalent despite the large amount of research countering them. First, however, it is important to consider some cross-cultural examples because as eye-opening as the mostly US-based research surveyed in this section has been in illuminating the complexities and refuting the misconceptions surrounding gendered language use, the studies that have been conducted elsewhere in the world help us understand, even better, the wide range of linguistic styles both within the United States and elsewhere and remind us of the need to situate all research in specific social and historical contexts.

## Do Women and Men of All Ages and All Ethnic, Racial, and Cultural Backgrounds Share the Same Gendered Differences in Their Language Use?

Lest the language ideologies dominant in the United States and some other countries be mistaken for a universal set of assumptions (correct or incorrect) about the existence and character of gender differences in language, studies from other societies remind us of the diversity not just in how individuals actually talk (as opposed to how they are assumed to talk) but also in the cultural norms and assumptions themselves.

In a classic article (Keenan [Ochs] 1974) about the linguistic practices of Malagasy-speaking women and men in Madagascar, for example, Elinor Ochs describes a very different set of language ideologies concerning gendered communicative styles than those that

prevail in most of the United States and Europe. Whereas many Americans and Europeans (including scholars!) assume that women are, or should be, more cooperative and polite than men, the people with whom Ochs worked in Madagascar in the 1970s assumed exactly the reverse. The two overarching Malagasy speech genres, *resaka* (ordinary, direct, everyday speech) and *kabary* (ceremonial, oratorical, indirect speech) were therefore thought to index femininity and masculinity, respectively. Women, Ochs claimed,

> are associated with direct criticism and haggling in markets. They are able to put others on the spot, to confront others with possibly offensive information where men cannot or prefer not. Women tend to be direct and open in manner. Men tend to conduct themselves with discretion and subtlety. Women dominate situations where directness is called for. Men, on the other hand, dominate situations where indirectness is desirable. (Keenan [Ochs] 1974:139)

Because women were more willing to confront others directly, men often used them to intervene in social conflicts. On the whole, however, Ochs reports that the most highly valued style involved indirectness and avoidance of affront, and so women in Madagascar were looked down upon because of their direct linguistic practices and the language ideologies that led people to judge these practices as appropriate only for children and the unsophisticated.

Don Kulick points out that the gendered patterns Ochs uncovered in Madagascar are by no means unique. Indeed, as Steven Feld, Bambi Schieffelin, and others have noted, similar practices can be found in places like Papua New Guinea. Kulick's own research analyzes how language, gender, and emotion are interwoven in culturally specific ways by the villagers of Gapun in Papua New Guinea. Anger, in particular, is viewed in Gapun as the province mainly of women, at least in its explicit articulation through a speech genre villagers call the *kros*. A *kros*, Kulick explains, is a manifestation of the negative dimension of the self that Gapuners call *hed*, which, as we saw in the discussion in Chapter 4 about Kulick's work on language socialization, makes people "individualistic, irascible, selfish, unbending, haughty, and proud" (1992:19). Women are considered less capable of controlling their *hed* than men, and one result of this perceived inability is that it is only women villagers who will engage in an angry, obscene shouting match known as a *kros*. Far from being the

cooperative, consensus-seeking, accommodative speakers that some scholars (e.g., Maltz and Borker 1982; Tannen 1990) have assumed all women are, the women in Gapun, much like the women of Madagascar whom Ochs studied, use a much more direct, confrontational, and even vulgar style in their disputes, as can be seen in this excerpt from a typical *kros* between two sisters, Sake and Erapo, who were arguing because Sake had caught Erapo's son red-handed as he was shooting coffee beans at Sake's pig:[8]

Sake: No good rotten big black hole!
Erapo: Smelly cunt bloody bastard!
Sake: I was talking to Erapo [sarcastic]. I was talking good about the rubbish [i.e., the coffee beans], Erapo gets up and swears at me. Fucking cunthole bastard you! (Kulick 1998:93)

The *kros* continues on in this vein for quite some time, Kulick reports, and ends in threats of physical violence. In contrast to this sort of confrontation, the styles of communication favored by men in Gapun emphasize cooperation and the importance of community. Anger is generally concealed in the talk that goes on in the men's house, even when there is a conflict between two of the participants. In such cases, the anger is eventually revealed, but only in a very tentative and temporary fashion, after which it is recontextualized and reconcealed. The dominant language ideology in Gapun values this kind of controlled expression of anger, followed by an immediate resuppression of this emotion that Gapuners consider so dangerous. The gendered nature of these linguistic expressions of emotion demonstrates the need to study such interactions ethnographically as they occur in actual social interactions.

Even in cultural contexts in which the language ideologies concerning gendered differences in linguistic practices are more in keeping with those that are predominant in the United States and Europe, the same need to study the specificities of these ideologies and practices applies. For Japan, for instance, Miyako Inoue reports that the extremely distinctive "Japanese women's language," assumed to exist by many Japanese and non-Japanese alike, serves as a powerful language ideology in which women and men are said to speak differently at all levels of language, including extra-linguistic features such as very high pitch, and discursive practices such as being soft-spoken, polite, gentle, and empathetic. "But here," Inoue writes, "is a little public secret: the very simple, yet obstinately disregarded,

fact is that most women in Japan do not have access to – did not systematically learn and cannot skillfully produce – the speech forms identified as women's language in their habitual speech repertoire" (Inoue 2006:3). So, why then is there an "almost theological avowal" of dramatic gender differences in linguistic practices in Japan?

Through a detailed analysis, Inoue debunks the myth of allegedly ancient roots of "Japanese women's language," tracing its origins instead to a particular historical era in the not-so-distant past: the late Meiji period (1888–1912), a time when Japan was engaged in dramatic social changes involving modernization, capitalism, and nationalism. Far from being an ancient, widespread, traditional way that all Japanese women actually spoke, the grammatical forms and discursive styles now considered to be "Japanese women's language" began in the late nineteenth century, Inoue argues, as "schoolgirl speech," which, male commentators of the time claimed, was "vulgar" and "lazy" because it omitted honorifics and used different utterance endings (Inoue 2006:57). Ironically, however, other male writers of the time saw this style as suitable for the kinds of novels that they wanted to write – novels that incorporated dialogue and reported speech, much as Western novels of the time did. Thus, what was initially a stigmatized form of talk that was said to have been used among a small set of upperclass schoolgirls in the late nineteenth century came to be employed in novels, newspaper reports, advertisements, and other print media to represent the way that all Japanese women spoke (or were supposed to speak). Over time, through reading and eventually hearing on the TV and radio this "Japanese women's language," many people in Japan came to associate this way of speaking with femininity, Japaneseness, and modernity. Inoue calls this process one of *indexical inversion* because "it actively constructs the very reality that it claims to be representing" (2006:51). Often, Inoue writes, language "does not wait until the category it refers to or indexes is 'out there'"; instead, as she shows in the case of "Japanese women's language," indexicality is involved in the very creation of the category of modern Japanese women (2006:107). Then, through repeated linguistic practice influenced by language ideologies, the ways that Japanese women actually speak come to be informed by ideas about how they should speak, which then in turn come to be influenced by how women actually speak. Inoue's research therefore provides an illuminating case study of the performative and recursive nature of indexicality.

## Some Thoughts on Myths and Realities

Much of this chapter has been devoted to debunking some widespread myths – that is, some inaccurate language ideologies. Across all of the research we have explored, we see that language and gender are related in complex and variable ways. Far from being reducible to simplistic and dualistic generalizations stating something like, "All women speak like Venusians, and all men speak like Martians," the realities of the relationship between language and gender must be determined by studying actual language use, and ideas surrounding that language use, in actual communities of practice.

Let us return now to the second question posed at the outset of the chapter: which group of high school students studied by Judith Baxter (2006:164, 170) was composed solely of girls, and which solely of boys? Recall that the teenagers were discussing what items would be most useful to survivors of a plane crash in a desert. Can the characteristics of these two groups' discussions reveal their composition? As Deborah Cameron, author of *The Myth of Mars and Venus: Do Men and Women Really Speak Different Languages*, notes in her analysis of these two conversations (2007b:61–64), compelling arguments could be made for either Group A as the all-girls group and Group B as the all-boys group, or vice versa. For example, it could be said that Group B's discussion was more cooperative; Speaker C politely solicits suggestions from the other group members, and there is no overt conflict. In contrast, Group A's members could be said to interact more competitively, with open conflict emerging as Speaker G challenged the other speakers and participants interrupted one another. Such an analysis might encourage someone who assumed women's communicative styles were more cooperative and less competitive than men's to conclude that Group A was made up of boys and Group B of girls.

On the other hand, even though Group B's discussion displayed more cooperative features in some respects, in other respects it seemed to involve more hierarchy and structure. Speaker C did solicit other group members' input, but Speaker C also seems to be assuming a leadership role in a businesslike fashion. No one does this in Group A. It could be said, therefore, that Group A is more cooperative and less competitive than Group B. If so, someone in agreement

with Tannen's (1990) and Maltz and Borker's (1982) generalizations regarding gendered linguistic practices might conclude that Group A was made up of girls and Group B of boys.

In fact, Group A was indeed made up of girls, and Group B was made up of boys. But, Cameron states,

> if you do not already know which group is which, it is difficult to deduce it from linguistic evidence alone. Each group's conversation contains both "competitive" and "cooperative" elements … Once you know C is a boy, though, it is tempting to use that information to resolve the ambiguity – in other words, to interpret his behaviour as on balance more "directive" than "facilitative". The claim that boys' talk is more competitive can thus become a self-fulfilling prophecy. (2007b:64)

If the realities of language and gender are really so complex and varied, however, why are the language ideologies concerning female talkativeness or male verbal competitiveness that can be found in the vignettes presented by Tannen (1990) and others so recognizable to us? Cameron (2007b) explains that it happens because of the tendency of all people to rely at least in part on stereotyping when processing information. It is not just ignorant or prejudiced people who stereotype, Cameron states, but everyone because stereotyping provides us with convenient shortcuts in determining what people are like and how we should treat them. The downside, however, is that such stereotypes "can reinforce unjust prejudices, and make us prone to seeing only what we expect or want to see" (Cameron 2007b:14). When we see someone who fits our preconceptions – say, a woman who is extremely talkative, for example – we easily "supply the cultural script that makes them meaningful and 'typical'" (Cameron 1997:48). When we encounter someone who does not fit a particular stereotype, however, we tend either not to notice or to explain the case away as an aberration.

Why should we care if one or more of our gendered language ideologies might be inaccurate or at least overly simplistic? There are many real-world implications of inaccurate language ideologies – in the workplace, in family life, in court cases, and in interpersonal relationships. Women, men, and children all suffer when gendered assumptions regarding communicative styles

and identities are inaccurate or overly rigid. What the research described in this chapter clearly demonstrates is that complexity and variability best characterize the relationship of language to gender. We will come to a similar conclusion in the next chapter after exploring the ways in which language relates to race and ethnicity.